firmly on the fence. The hierarchy agreed privately that Kevin could not be recalled, but never said so publicly. They hung me out to dry.

Sport moves on quickly; the controversy had very little relevance to our priority, fashioning a new team. It was wearing and distracting, a waste of mental energy since it was the only thing most people wanted to talk about. There were times I longed for the simplicity and purity of attempting to score as many runs as possible.

Though we lost that summer's opening series against Sri Lanka, in such gutting fashion that Alice had to talk me out of walking away, the first green shoots of recovery were detectable. Five of the six changes we made from the team that surrendered in Sydney contributed positively to the drawn first Test at Lord's.

Joe Root made a powerful point with an unbeaten 200, Matt Prior scored 86 and provided the solidity and direction expected of a senior pro. Gary Ballance contributed a second-innings century. Moeen Ali, on debut, played with the dexterity and assurance of someone vastly more experienced. Chris Jordan, an effervescent presence, took a wicket with his third delivery in Test cricket. Liam Plunkett, recalled after seven years, showed fantastic stamina.

Newer guys were free from scar tissue. They had everything you would want as a captain, inherent talent, rawness around the edges balanced by hunger and a willingness to listen. Ben Stokes, who had scored a wonderful maiden Test hundred on a cracked pitch at Perth, came into the side for the subsequent series against India.

It was still open season on me. Shane Warne was chirping away, and KP, a markedly similar character, turned up to watch us from a hospitality box in the second Test against India at Lord's. Inevitably, he was a magnet for the cameras. I trust I am not being unkind in suggesting his appearance was orchestrated.

We were back to the old routine, of Test cricket testing character.

We bowled too short after preparing a green wicket and were about eighty runs under par when we batted, despite another Ballance hundred. My captaincy was justifiably criticized, since I was too slow to change tactics. We lost, as badly in our own conditions as India did in Mumbai in 2012, but I looked around the changing room and felt a tightness of spirit we had not had for quite a while.